

Individual Training – Key Takeaways

Adult Learning Principles in Defence Training — Days 1-2

Originator Individual Training Review Date September 2026 Version Working draft v0.2

Commander's Question

What is the Army approach to individual training?

A working synthesis of the evidence so far, not a record of the sessions — to be tested and refined as the activity continues.

Emerging Takeaways

- 1 Individual training exists to produce operational competence and effect.** Course completion and education are means, not ends. Success is whether the individual can perform to standard in their role and on operations.
- 2 A common standard does not require an identical learning journey.** People arrive shaped by genetics, prior experience, education, environment and stress, and neurodiversity adds further variation. Army can hold the performance standard firm while varying the route people take to reach it.
- 3 Capability is built, not simply selected for.** The brain stays adaptable, so practice, repetition, feedback and experience keep developing performance well beyond initial training. Where operational risk permits, learners need room to fail safely and try again before facing consequential conditions.
- 4 Sequence training to the limits of working memory.** Establish foundations, chunk complexity, then use retrieval and spaced practice to drive skills toward automaticity. Automaticity is what frees capacity for judgement under pressure.
- 5 Stress is a training variable to be managed, not removed.** Too little challenge disengages; too much blocks learning. Complexity and pressure should increase deliberately as competence grows, so the learner finishes able to perform under operational conditions.
- 6 Learner state governs how much learning is possible.** Sleep, fatigue, nutrition, emotional state, distraction and psychological safety materially affect capacity to learn. So does purpose — people commit when they can see why the training matters to their role.
- 7 The instructor is the adaptive element in the system.** Instructors must read learner state, check understanding, give feedback, adjust pacing and know when specialist support is needed. Multiple modes of instruction, assistive technology and reasonable adjustment improve access without lowering the standard.
- 8 The science is evidence, not the approach.** Neuroplasticity, cognitive load, neurodiversity and Universal Design for Learning — like ADDIE, SAM, 70:20:10 and Bloom's — inform how Army designs and delivers training; none is the approach itself. The binding constraint remains training governance and the speed at which Army can adapt training.

The Emerging Continuum

Foundation → Guided Practice → Independent Practice → Applied / Experiential Learning → Performance Under Pressure

Instructor direction decreases across the continuum while learner autonomy, complexity and pressure increase. How far and how fast an individual moves is set by:

Risk × Complexity × Learner Experience & Competence × Required Operational Outcome

High-risk and foundational training sits at the left: standardised, directive, tightly controlled. Experienced learners, leadership and professional development sit further right, with greater autonomy, reflection and judgement. Much of the right-hand end happens in units, not schools — workplace experience, coaching, practice and reflection — and is part of the training system, not an adjunct to it.

Emerging Proposition

Army develops individuals progressively toward a common operational standard — from foundation, through guided and independent practice, to applied learning and performance under pressure — adapting the direction, support, complexity and pressure applied to the risk, complexity, learner competence and required operational outcome. The standard is common; the journey to it need not be identical.

An emerging proposition, now carrying two days of evidence, to be tested against the sessions still to come.